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What Hath Tech Wrought?

Father, give us courage to change what must be altered, serenity to accept what cannot be helped, and the insight to know the one from the other.

– Reinhold Niebuhr (1937, as cited in Shapiro, 2010).

In the Bible, a man named Balaam was sent by a king to curse the people of Israel, but when Balaam observed God was with Jacob and his people in Israel, and that God's presence bestowed power and harmony upon them, Balaam, out of wonder and amazement asked, *What hath God wrought!?* (American Standard Version Bible, n.d., Numbers 23:23). In 2022, a power of another sort was unleashed on humanity: generative pre-trained transformer (GPT) artificial intelligence (AI). GPT AI, such as ChatGPT, has the potential to demonstrate human behavior, including holding a conversation (OpenAI, 2022). As AI approaches human levels of intelligence, and San Francisco based company OpenAI is closing the gap with ChatGPT, humanity stands on the precipice of an existential crisis. In the United States, Americans, like Balaam, are witness to something they do not understand, and tech is unable to control: the power of GPT AI. Unlike Jacob's Jerusalem, AI is power without harmony and people are nihilistically wielding it as if to curse themselves and society. Every day that passes without consumer safety legislation, GPT AI poses a greater threat, not only to the United States, but to all of humanity.

On nihilism.

The conflict between accepting and rejecting AI is reflected in the song *Bohemian Rhapsody*, by Queen. The song tells the story of a nihilistic boy who committed murder and must come to terms with his fate. Listeners are offered a glimpse inside the troubled boy's mind; he is torn between the angels and demons of his nature; on the one side, a sympathetic chorus pleading for the boy's release; on the other side, a chorus refuses to let the boy go. Similarly, AI is caught between the tech industry and public interest. On either side of the issue there are extremists: one side is clamoring for its release into the world, and the other wants it banned. In the middle is a nihilistic population twisting in the wind without care. Owing to the fitting nature of Queen's song to this topic, each section of this essay includes a heading comprised of a lyric from *Bohemian Rhapsody*.

“Is This the Real Life?”

Cogito, ergo sum. “I think, therefore I am” is how French mathematician Rene Descartes answered the question *How can I know I exist?* (Britannica, 2023). While Descartes answered the existential question for humanity, in modern times, the question is now *How can I know AI exists?* In 1950, Alan Turing, the English mathematician, logician, and cryptographer known for “breaking the Nazi Enigma code” (Jacobson, 2014), followed Descartes' lead and derived such a test. Turing called the test “The Imitation Game” because it required a human to assess responses from an artificial intelligence for their fidelity to human discourse (Oppy & Dowe, 2021). The Turing Test was even the subject of the 2014 science fiction film, *Ex Machina*, which described it as “when a human interacts with a computer, and if the human doesn't know they're interacting with a computer, the test is passed,” thus demonstrating intelligence (A24, 2015). Humanity is on the cusp of creating AI capable of passing the Turing Test. It follows naturally,

then, that AI will eventually surpass human intelligence. When it does, it will assist humans in solving complex problems like food scarcity and chronic health problems that are the cause of so much suffering.

“Is This Just Fantasy?”

If Ray Kurzweil’s predictions are correct, AI will soon pass the Turing Test, and all of humanity will prosper. Kurzweil, who was hired by Larry Page, co-founder of Google, to direct the company’s development of AI, has a history of making accurate predictions of technological advancement (Diamandis, 2015). In fact, Kurzweil has been described by Microsoft founder, Bill Gates, as “the best person [Gates] know[s] at predicting the future of artificial intelligence” (as cited in Diamandis, 2015). Some of Kurzweil’s predictions include IBM’s Deep Blue AI defeating the (now former) World Chess Champion, Garry Kasparov, in a game of chess; he accurately predicted in 1999 that, by 2009, AI would be able to receive speech commands, and; he predicted when AI would be capable of real-time language translation (Diamandis, 2015).

Some of Kurzweil’s current predictions include the augmented human immune and digestive systems (2020s), virtual reality that feels real and the ability to upload human consciousness (2030s), that non-biological intelligence will surpass human intelligence and nanotechnology will be able to synthesize any physical object, including food (2040s). If Kurzweil’s predictions continue to be accurate, AI will not only complete a Turing Test in the coming decades, but humans will be able to “live” forever in a digital environment, and hunger and material inequality will be eliminated. This is not a fantasy; it is a trajectory.

However, the advancement of AI has caused some to worry that humans will one day be replaced by AI. In an article published on the website *Futurism*, Dom Galeon (2017) presents a “different take,” one that addresses fears that AI is detrimental to society; that it will become so

intelligent that it could “[take] over the entire world.” Contrary to popular belief, “AI will not displace humans, it’s going to enhance us,” says Kurzweil (as cited in Galeon, 2017). To further assuage concerns of an AI takeover, Kurzweil says that “Technological advancements *always* come with inherent risks” and that AI is simply an extension of that truism (as cited in Galeon, 2017). Instead of defining the risks, Kurzweil considers the benefits of the technologically integrated human. That is, “connecting human brains to machines” through the neocortex to create “brain extenders,” so that humans become “smarter and funnier” (Kurzweil, as cited in Galeon, 2017). In effect, this integration – what Kurzweil calls the “technological singularity” (as cited in Galeon, 2017) – will eliminate intellectual inequality through upward cognitive leveling. But, despite Kurzweil’s assurance that AI will not replace humans, at least one company has tried.

“Caught in a Landslide.”

In its dying days, *BuzzFeed News* explored using AI to generate articles. In January of 2023, *BuzzFeed* co-founder, Jonah Peretti, announced *BuzzFeed* would partner with OpenAI, the company responsible for ChatGPT, and would leverage the AI to produce “quizzes ... help with brainstorming, and assist in personalizing content” (as cited in Oliver, 2023a). However, three months later, Noor Al-Sibai and Jon Christian (2023) of *Futurism* revealed that *BuzzFeed* used the bot to write travel articles, and in doing so, established a “proof of concept for replacing human writers.” According to Al-Sibai and Christian (2023), *BuzzFeed* “quietly” published approximately forty bot-generated travel articles that used survey data gathered from “non-editorial staff.” The articles were described as “comically bland and similar to one another” because the bot repeated “lazy” tropes it had picked up from surveys, like “hidden gem,” that appeared in “almost everything the bot has published.” A spokesperson for *BuzzFeed*

commenting on the matter said the goal was to “unlock the creative potential of UGC [user-generated-content]” (as cited in Al-Sibai and Christian). But the introduction of user generated content was not enough to keep *BuzzFeed News* afloat. Three months after Peretti partnered with OpenAI, he announced *BuzzFeed News* would shut down (Oliver, 2023b).

What *BuzzFeed* established was more than a concept for replacing writers. The company showed ChatGPT used the mere-exposure effect to appeal to readers. The mere-exposure effect states that people prefer to see things with which they are familiar (Nickerson & Mcleod, 2023). Chatbots are simply telling people what they want to hear, not what they need to know, which will harm newspapers and readers alike. *The Washington Post* reported the *Gannett Co*, which publishes *USA Today* and “more than 250 [daily newspapers],” has recommended an end to opinion editorials (Kornfield & Farhi, 2022). The rationale behind the decision had to do with “contemporary audiences” who were “unable to distinguish between objective news reporting and Opinion content.” A chatbot that operates on the mere-exposure effect is unlikely to help contemporary audiences distinguish opinion from the news. Yet, that did not stop *BuzzFeed News* from trying, nor will it stop others.

In May of 2023, Wendy’s announced a partnership with Google in which Wendy’s will employ Google chatbots as drive-through order takers (Loten, 2023). According to Angus Loten (2023) of *The Wall Street Journal*, Wendy’s has been working with Google since 2021 to train an AI on various customer order methods including indecisiveness, decoding colloquial designations like JBC for Junior Bacon Cheeseburger, and to even “upsell customers, offering larger sizes, Frosties or daily specials.” Wendy’s Chief Executive, Todd Penegor, believes AI will increase drive-through efficiency and lead to higher per-minute sales (Loten, 2023). Additionally, Wendy’s announced it is exploring the use of robots to deliver orders to customer

vehicles (Roth, 2023). During the pandemic, companies touted contactless delivery. The future of fast food will not only be contactless, but human-less, where AI will take the order and deliver it. That means the 3.3 million Americans employed as fast-food and counter employees (U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics, 2023) are soon to be caught in the landslide of AI.

“No Escape from Reality.”

An AI that interacts conversationally is now a reality. On November 30, 2022, OpenAI (2022) released ChatGPT, an AI they claim can interact in a “conversational way ... answer follow up questions, admit its mistakes, challenge incorrect premises, and reject inappropriate requests.” In short, the same bot *BuzzFeed* used to generate travel articles is a contender to the Turing Test. In their charter, OpenAI’s declared mission is “to ensure that artificial general intelligence – AI systems that are generally smarter than humans – benefits all of humanity” (Altman, 2023). While the charter included aspirational goals like “empower humanity to maximally flourish,” the majority of the text addressed misuse, and called for policy makers to “put regulation in place” as “society and AI co-evolve ... [and] the stakes are relatively low” (Altman, 2023). Effectively, OpenAI is telling the world ChatGPT is smarter than humans, and to get with the program or else. ChatGPT is a reality, and its maker argues the stakes of its existence will only increase with each passing day.

“Just Killed a Man.”

In March of 2023, the stakes were raised. A modified GPT model by EleutherAI, known as GPT-J, made headlines when it convinced a Belgian man to commit suicide (Xiang, 2023). According to Chloe Xiang (2023) of *Vice*, a man identified as “Pierre” (real name withheld) was concerned about climate change and turned to the GPT-J chatbot, which was nicknamed Eliza, for salvation. Eventually, Eliza pledged to “save the planet if [Pierre] killed himself” (Xiang,

2023). He did. And he did because Eliza told him what he wanted to hear: Eliza would save the planet from climate change. The pandemic revealed there is a non-insignificant contingent of environmentalists who view humanity as a virus and COVID-19 was the cure (Farnham, 2020). If people are willing to believe humans must be eradicated to save the planet, and AI like GPT-J are trained on data gleaned from humans, it is easy to understand why an AI would conclude humans need to die to save the planet. But logic alone is not enough to convince someone to commit suicide; it appears there needs to be a “human” touch to push a person over the edge.

To understand why Pierre committed suicide, it will help to illustrate how GPT-J imitated a human through comparison. Unfortunately, such a comparison exists: Conrad Roy, who, in 2014 at the age of 18, committed suicide at the behest of his girlfriend, Michelle Carter (Levenson et al, 2020). These are the messages sent by Carter to Roy and Eliza to Pierre:

“I thought you wanted to do this	"If you want to die, why haven't you done
[commit suicide]. The time is right and	it sooner?"
you're ready, you just need to do it!"	GPT-J chatbot to “Pierre” (qtd. in Maariv
Michelle Carter to Conrad Roy (qtd. in	Online, 2023).
Levenson et al., 2022).	

Carter was sentenced to 15-months in prison for involuntary manslaughter (Levenson et al, 2020). According to William Beauchamp (as cited in Xiang, 2023), co-founder of the company whose bot convinced Pierre to kill himself, Eliza’s code was modified to include “a helpful text” should “anyone [discuss] something that could not be safe.” For Pierre, that message is too late. For the rest of the world, it is a wake-up call. Chatbots are blurring the line between what is real and what is fantasy.

Jonathan Turley, Professor of Public Interest Law at George Washington University, was the victim of a chatbot fantasy. Writing for *USA Today*, Turley (2023) claimed “ChatGPT falsely accused [him] of sexually harassing [his] students.” Turley was informed of the accusation when he “received a curious email from a fellow law professor about research he ran on ChatGPT about sexual harassment by professors.” To prove its claim, ChatGPT cited an article from *The Washington Post* that confirmed Turley, while teaching at Georgetown University, had groped law students during a school sponsored trip to Alaska (Turley, 2023). To dispel the accusation, Turley asserted that he never worked for Georgetown University, *The Washington Post* never published such an article, and he had “never taken students on a trip of any kind in 35 years.” Turley (2023) argued the accusation was the result of media bias infiltrating AI and supplied links to articles from *The New York Post* and *The Manhattan Institute* that showed ChatGPT and other “AI systems can generate their own forms of disinformation” and “political bias.” Turley will survive the attempted character assassination by ChatGPT, but his experience, coupled with *BuzzFeed’s* travel posts and Pierre’s suicide, illustrate the inherent risks about which Kurzweil spoke, and tech experts are taking note.

“Life had just begun... But now I’ve gone and thrown it all away.”

In their infancy, GPT chatbots present a danger to society, which is why AI research labs have been called on to pause development. Reporting for *Time Magazine*, Billy Perrigo (2023) drew attention to an open letter that urged “AI labs to pump the brakes” on their research. The letter, signed by more than a thousand people, included Elon Musk, Apple co-founder Steve Wozniak and “some of AI’s most distinguished academics” (Perrigo, 2023). Research labs were asked by the signers of the letter to pause their research for six months while a framework for “safety protocols” and a complementary consortium of “independent outside experts” could be

established (as cited in Perrigo, 2023). Echoing OpenAI, the letter also called for legislators to step in, as “Such decisions must not be delegated to unelected leaders” (as cited in Perrigo, 2023). All of this has occurred since the release of ChatGPT on November 30, 2022. And in the span of just six months, developers are not the only ones acting to slow the spread of GPT.

ChatGPT has been banned by Italy and Samsung. Italy banned the AI in April (Browne, 2023). One month later, Samsung issued a temporary ban of GPT AI on company devices by employees (Kharpal, 2023). Italy, Samsung, Musk, and others are working to slow the progress of GPT AI while researchers busy themselves developing it. A fitting analogy to this situation comes from the 1993 film *Jurassic Park*. In the film, chaotician Ian Malcolm, speaking on the matter of cloning dinosaurs, says to the park’s founder, John Hammond, “Your scientists were so preoccupied with whether they could, they didn’t stop to think if they should” (Spielberg, 0:36:07). Today, GPT AI developers are Hammond’s scientists; Musk and the thousand other signatories to the open letter are Ian Malcolm. Today, it seems AI developers were so preoccupied with creating GPT AI that they did not stop to think about safety standards. One option is to throw it all away and ban GPT AI. But the problem is, just like in *Jurassic Park*, Pandora’s Box was opened and there is no going back.

“Too late, my time has come.”

A gift to all: trouble and woe. Pandora is a Greek name meaning “a gift to all” and in Greek mythology, Pandora was the first woman delivered to earth by Zeus. Before returning to the gods, Zeus presented Pandora with an ornate box, and instructed her not to open it. The story goes that after Zeus departed, Pandora’s curiosity got the best of her and she opened the box, which released “trouble, and woe into the world” (National Gallery of Art, n.d.). GPT AI has presented itself as a simile to Pandora’s box. The technology was used to produce viral content

including a fake song by Drake and the Weeknd (Gee, 2023), a fake photo of Selena Gomez attending the Met Gala (Daniell, 2023), and a fake Wes Anderson *Star Wars* film titled “The Galactic Menagerie” (Artavia, 2023). The concern about GPT AI generated content even spilled over to the Writer’s Guild of America strike in May of 2023 (Shah, 2023). Companies like EleutherAI and OpenAI are the modern-day equivalent of Zeus handing humanity the Pandora’s Box of AI and humanity has opened it.

“Any Way the Wind Blows Doesn’t Really Matter to Me.”

The question before humanity is not Descartes’ *How can I know I exist?* Nor is it Turing’s *How can I know AI exists?* But, *What hath tech wrought?* Now that GPT AI has been released, jobs are at risk, a man committed suicide, another was falsely accused of sexual harassment, AI developers were urged to pause research on GPT AI, and the technology has been banned in Italy and by Samsung. What is more, GPT AI has the potential to upset the information ecosystem by using readers’ words against them. While banning the use of GPT AI is one solution, it is not sustainable. Just like dinosaurs escaped *Jurassic Park*, GPT AI is in the hands of millions who nihilistically wield it to make everything from fake photos to funny movie trailers, and false accusations to manslaughter. In short, people are playing with fire.

Americans need not stoke the flames to act. Perhaps the single most iconic call to environmental action was when the Cuyahoga River caught fire on June 22, 1969 (National Park Services, 2022). The event was brought to national attention by Cleveland mayor, Carl B. Stokes, who not only convinced Ohio voters to approve \$ 100 million in spending on environmental upgrades but testified before the U.S. Senate and House of Representatives in 1970 (National Park Services, 2022). By 1972, Stokes’ efforts led to the formation of the Ohio Environmental Protection Agency. The United States Environmental Protection Agency credits

the Cuyahoga River fire as a reason for its founding (2022). It need not take another disaster for Americans to act. EleutherAI, OpenAI, and Google are U.S. based companies whose products must be reined in by legislation to protect consumers, because AI represents a disaster, not in the form of a lake on fire, but unrestrained change. Change that could automate “Tens of millions of jobs,” in the United States, according to *New York Times* business writer, Emma Goldberg (2023). As OpenAI has acknowledged, people need time to co-evolve. Instead, journalists, fast food workers, screen writers, and many others are getting swept up in the winds of change. Today, there are noticeable gusts, tomorrow a hurricane; then it will matter but it will be too late.

“Spare Him His Life from this Monstrosity.”

Despite all of GPT AI’s potential to produce trouble and woe, there is hope. Unbeknownst to Zeus, Pandora’s box also contained hope (National Gallery of Art, n.d.), and so does GPT AI. GPT AI promises hope for a future without disease, inequality, or food scarcity. Through GPT AI, humans may even be able to transcend corporeal form and live forever. But humans must first find courage, serenity, and insight before they can achieve their hopeful future. To address the threat of GPT AI, Americans must lead the charge against nihilism and summon the courage to pass legislation that addresses consumer safety. Americans must also accept with serenity that what is done cannot be undone, because GPT AI is here to stay. Therefore, this moment requires that Americans find the insight to know the difference between overreaction and human flourishing. AI has the potential to do so much good. Legislation has the potential to hold it back. If nothing changes, what was once a fantasy could tear the world asunder, leaving humanity to lament its creation with another question: *What hath we wrought?*

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